

USER GUIDE

Version 2.0

An expert advisor developed for today's gold market.
Works on any chart timeframe · XAUUSD

Developed by Shaikh Sadi

Runs on any account — no activation step

1 · Why Relay Exists

Gold is not the market it was ten years ago. Since 2024-2025 it moves in long, violent, news-charged waves — a regime that punishes the classic “one-size-fits-all” robots designed on the calm ranges of the last decade. Relay was built the other way around: **designed, tuned and validated on the modern regime first**, using years of real-tick data, then stress-checked against a full decade so its protections know what an unfriendly market looks like.

Inside, several specialised engines share one account: a trend engine that rides the big waves with an adaptive trailing system, a fast engine that banks short bursts, and a quiet-market engine for the hours in between. Position size, stop distance and trail room all adapt automatically to the measured volatility regime — in storms Relay sizes down and breathes wider; in calm it tightens up.

Our Honesty

No strategy works forever — and anyone who promises otherwise is selling you a story. Markets move in regimes; an edge is a property of a regime, not a law of nature. Relay's edge is measured on the modern gold regime, and if that regime changes, its performance will change with it. That is exactly why the protection layer exists: hard risk caps, daily and weekly loss brakes, and a prop guardian are there for the days the market stops cooperating. We publish **ranges**, not promises; every number in this guide comes from controlled real-tick testing, and the losing months are disclosed next to the winning ones.

2 · Quick Start

1	Open an **XAUUSD** chart — any timeframe. Relay reads its own clocks internally.
2	Attach **Relay**. **The validated configuration is already compiled in** — every default you see is the tested value, so on a fresh chart there is nothing to load. **If you ran an earlier version of Relay**, press **Reset** in the Inputs tab first: MetaTrader remembers your previous values by input name and would carry them into the new build.
3	Enable **Algo Trading**. The dashboard should appear within seconds.
4	**Check the dollar gauge.** Relay reads your broker's EURUSD as a dollar-confirmation gauge and tries to detect its name by itself. If your broker names EURUSD with a suffix or prefix — **EURUSD.r**, EURUSDm, EURUSD.pro, EURUSD_i and so on — and Relay does not pick it up, simply type that exact name into **Dollar gauge symbol** in the Inputs tab. Open its D1 chart once so the daily history downloads, then reload Relay. The Experts log tells you which case you are in: it names the symbol it detected, or reports the dial off. Detection is not guaranteed on every broker, so please spend the thirty seconds — with the gauge off, Relay still trades, but without one of its measured drawdown protections.
5	Live trading runs on **licensed accounts only** — unlicensed charts show a red banner and refuse entries (backtesting is open to everyone). Contact the developer to license your account.
6	Leave it alone. No manual trades on the same account, no other EAs on the symbol.

The Dashboard



Top block — market state: regime chip (Calm/Stormy with the live volatility read), direction, confidence, and how much room the stops are giving. **Engine rows** — what each engine is doing right now (riding, waiting, resting). **Performance** — today / this month / all-time, win rate, the loss-brake meter and the next balance step at which size grows. **Account card** — broker, login, balance and account type, so a screenshot always tells the full story. **Last 10 trades** — every result with a plain-English reason for why it ended.

The News Card

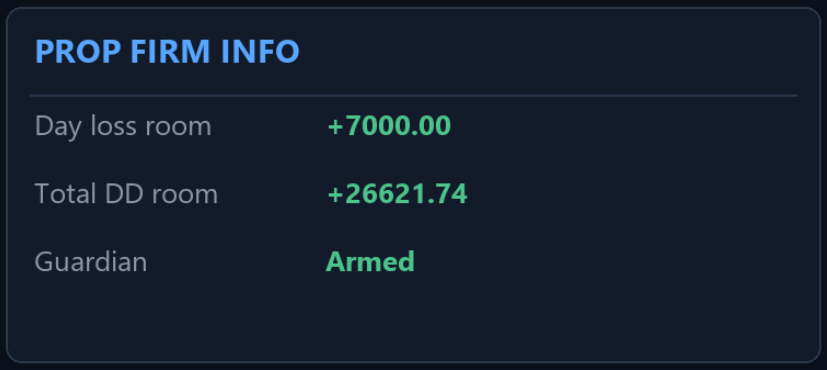
With the news filter switched on, the dashboard also carries the next **high-impact** event on the calendar — no matter how far away it is — on three rows:

Next news	The event's name, straight from your broker's MT5 calendar.
Due in	The wait in **total minutes**, with the same span restated in brackets — *2285 min (1d 14h)*. Both readings are the same number: 1 day 14 hours IS 2,285 minutes. Minutes are what matters when you are deciding whether to leave a position running.
Fcst / Prev	The market's **forecast** and the **previous** release, formatted the way the calendar means them — *F 190K P 175K*, or *F 4.3% P 4.1%*. The gap between the actual number and the forecast is what moves gold, so these are the two figures worth having in front of you. Some high-impact entries are **speeches** rather than data releases and carry no numbers at all; the row says so, and two further rows then show the next event that *does* have figures.

While an event is inside its blackout window the card switches to a red **HIGH IMPACT NOW** line instead. Turn the filter off and the rows disappear entirely. In **backtests** the archive file carries times and names but no figures, so Fcst / Prev reads ‘not published’ there; live charts use the MT5 calendar and show the real numbers.

3 · Prop Firm Mode

One switch reshapes Relay for funded-account rules: **percent risk sizing (0.35% per trade), one position at a time, and the news filter forced on** (news gaps are the one thing an equity guardian cannot outrun). A dedicated guardian then watches the firm's daily-loss and total-drawdown limits with a safety buffer, flattens everything before a limit can be touched, and halts for the day — or for good — if its floors are reached.



Day loss room — how many dollars remain before the daily-loss guardian steps in today. **Total DD room** — distance to the firm's total-drawdown floor. **Guardian** — Armed (green), Day halt, or HALTED. These three numbers are the ones a funded trader actually lives by; they sit on the dashboard whenever prop mode is on.

Measured on $100,000 with recorded real spreads

Year	Return	Max equity drawdown
2025 (full year)	+30.8%	2.7%
2026 (Jan-Aug)	+5.8%	3.0%

Defaults map to the common 5% daily / 10% total rule set; a trailing-total option covers firms that trail the equity peak. Backtest results — not a guarantee.

4 · Settings — Every Input Explained

Thirty-four inputs, six groups. Relay carries a further seventy measured values that are NOT on the dialog: every alternative to them was tested and lost money in at least one year, so they are compiled in rather than left out where they could be turned by mistake. The provided .set file ships every value at its validated default; the tables below tell you what each one does and when (if ever) to change it.

Group 1 · TRADING

Input	Default	What it does / when to change
Magic number	777001	Unique ID for Relay's own orders. Change only if another EA on the account uses the same number.
How the lot size is decided	Risk profile	Profile ladder (recommended), percent-of-balance risk, or a fixed lot. Everything below follows this choice.
Risk profile	High	**This is the risk dial.** Balance per 0.01 lot: Super Low $10,000 » Low $5,000 » Medium $1,000 » **High $500 (validated default; storm-adaptive)** » Custom. Measured cost of stepping down to Medium: roughly HALF the return and roughly half the 2025 drawdown (17.9% → 9.6%) — but also profit factor 2.35 → 1.92, and the storm-adaptive ladder is **only active on High**. A calmer curve is a real option; it is not free.
Custom step	250	Only for the Custom profile: your own balance-per-0.01-lot step.
Percent mode: risk per trade	0.75%	Only for percent mode: stop-distance-based risk per trade.
Fixed mode: lot size	0.01	Only for fixed mode. No compounding — size never grows.
Dollar gauge symbol	empty	Relay uses the broker's EURUSD as a dollar-confirmation gauge and tries to find it automatically. **Check this one on first attach.** If the Experts log says the dollar dial is off, type your broker's exact EURUSD name here — for example **EURUSD.r** on FP Markets, whose gold is XAUUSD.r. Also make sure that symbol has daily history: open its D1 chart once and scroll back, then restart Relay. The dial is a real contributor, so it is worth the thirty seconds.

How the lot size is decided — and why it is not martingale

Relay's default sizing is a **staircase**, not a smooth curve, which is why it can appear to jump between trades. The formula is exactly this:

lot = floor(balance ÷ step) × 0.01 × signal scale	
Balance step	On the default High profile the step is **$500**: $500-999 trades 0.01, $1,000 trades 0.02, $1,500 trades 0.03, and so on. Moving from $999 to $1,000 doubles the lot in a single step. This is the most common reason a jump gets noticed.

Volatility	In a storm regime the step tightens from $500 to $400, so the same balance sits one notch higher. At a $2,000 balance that is 0.04 in calm conditions and 0.05 in a storm — **a change with no change in balance at all**. This is deliberate, and it was measured rather than assumed.
Signal quality	A full three-of-three timeframe agreement trades at **100%** size, two-of-three at **60%**, one-of-three at **40%**; the quick BOLT trades run at **50%**. Two consecutive trades can therefore differ several times over on quality alone.
The floor	**None of the quality scaling above can act while the calculated lot is already at your broker's minimum.** Halving 0.01 still gives 0.01. Measured on the test ledger at the $500 minimum balance: **100% of BOLT's trades and 61% of the trend engine's sat at 0.01 lots** in the first test year — every engine trading the same size regardless of conviction. By the second year, with the balance grown, that had fallen to 97% and 29%. The conviction and per-engine multipliers become real somewhere above **$1,000**; below that you are running the strategy's decisions at a flat minimum size. This is broker lot granularity, not a fault in the logic — but it is the honest reason the recommended balance is $1,000 rather than the $500 floor.

This is not martingale. Martingale means increasing size after a loss in order to recover it. The result of your previous trade is not an input to the formula above at any point — there is no term for it. Size grows only as the *account* grows, and it steps back down the same staircase if the balance falls. You can verify this in about a minute: set **VerboseLog** to true, and every trade prints a line such as *LOT: 0.04 lots | SL 12.35 | risk 2.10% of 2000.00*. Compare a trade taken straight after a loss with one taken after a win at the same balance — the lot is identical.

If you would rather have no steps at all: set **How the lot size is decided** to *Fixed lot* for a constant size, or *Percent-of-balance risk* for smooth scaling. Nothing else in the strategy changes.

Group 2 · STRATEGIES

Input	Default	What it does / when to change
Strategy BOLT (fast trades)	true	The quick engine. **Leave it on.** Its own ledger looks small, but switching it off was measured to cost **85% of the 2026 test year** and take drawdown from 7.3% to 35.4% — its trades shape when the big ones happen.
Strategy COVE (quiet markets)	true	The quiet-market engine, working the hours the trend engine sits out. **Leave it on.** Switching it off was measured to cost **30% of the 2026 test year** and double the drawdown.
Take profit sooner in a market going nowhere	0 — off	**Off by default, and not a proven setting — see the panel above.** A share of what this market is actually travelling, not a distance. Over six flat weeks it turned -$35 into +$99 and lifted the win rate from 44% to 51%; across the full year it cost $1,574. 0.45 is the measured value.
Go flat before the weekend	true	Closes everything before the weekend. Relay reads your broker's OWN published Friday session close and goes flat **five hours before it**, so the same real moment is chosen whatever timezone your broker's server runs in — no setting needed. The Experts log states the resolved time on startup. Turn this off only if you accept weekend gap risk.

Take profit sooner in a market going nowhere

This one is **off by default and is not a proven setting**. It is documented in full because it is the only dial on the list whose trade-off runs in both directions, and you should see both before you touch it.

What it does. When the market is not travelling, Relay stops waiting for a large move and takes profit at a nearer target instead. The number you enter is **not a distance** — it is a *share of what this market has actually been travelling* over its last 480 bars. At 0.45 in a market that typically runs $49 the target sits near $22; in one that runs $25 it sits near $11. The distance moves with the market on its own, and there is nothing to re-tune when conditions change.

Measured over six weeks	On 12 Aug – 23 Sep 2026, a stretch in which the default build lost money: net **-$34.96 » +$99.31** and win rate **43.75% » 51.22%**. In a market that will not run, wins arrive more often and the account stops bleeding.
Measured over the year	The same setting costs **-$1,574** across 2026 as a whole. The reason is simple and is not a bug: the market also counts as quiet during stretches that were paying, and a near target caps the runs that make the year. What buys the bad weeks is paid for by the good ones.
Who it is for	Leave it at **0** unless you have a specific reason. It is worth considering only if you would rather grind through a flat market than sit through it, and you accept a smaller year in exchange. **0.45** is the value that was measured; 0.60 was measured too and was worse, because it places the target almost exactly where the stop moves to break-even and cuts the trade at the moment it becomes safe.

Group 3 · NEWS FILTER

Input	Default	What it does / when to change
Enable news filter	false	Switching it ON also puts the **next high-impact event** on the dashboard — name, minute countdown, forecast and previous (see section 2). OFF by default for retail — measured across years, always-on filtering cost more than it saved. Prop mode forces it ON regardless.
High impact only	true	false also blocks medium-impact events (more blocked hours).
Currencies to watch	USD,EUR	Comma list matched against the calendar feed.
Block minutes before / after	30 / 30	The blackout window around each event.
Also close open trades	false	true flattens before events too (prop mode does this automatically).

Group 4 · PROTECTION

Input	Default	What it does / when to change
Daily/weekly loss brake	true	The kill switch master toggle. Leave on.
Max daily loss	3%	Trading pauses for the day past this. Measured optimum — tightening to 2-2.5% was tested and LOST money while RAISING drawdown.

Max weekly loss	6%	Same idea, weekly horizon.
Hard risk cap	5%	Any single trade whose stop would risk more than this % of balance is SKIPPED (not shrunk). The last line of defence.

Group 5 · PROP FIRM MODE

Input	Default	What it does / when to change
Prop mode	false	The one switch: %-risk sizing, one position at a time, news filter forced on, guardian armed. See section 3.
Risk per trade	0.35%	Validated prop sizing. 0.50% passes recent years but halves the long-run safety cushion — documented dial, not default.
Firm's daily loss limit	5%	Set to YOUR firm's rule. The guardian acts before the limit with a safety buffer.
Firm's total drawdown limit	10%	Same, for the total-drawdown rule.
Total limit trails equity peak	false	true for firms whose total limit trails the equity high-water mark.
Daily limit is % of	0 — initial balance	Firms disagree on what the daily percentage is taken from, and getting it wrong is what breaches an account. **0** = the initial balance, which is FTMO's rule and the safe default. **1** = the current balance, so the allowance grows as the account grows. **2** = whichever of the two is larger. Match your firm's wording exactly.
Day loss measured from	1 — the day's peak	Where the day's loss is counted from. **0** = the balance at the day's start, which is how FTMO words it. **1** = the highest point reached during the day, which is stricter and will stand Relay down earlier. The default is the stricter of the two on purpose: it can cost a trade, it cannot cost the account.
Shift the daily reset	0 hours	Your firm's trading day may not begin at your broker's midnight. Enter the difference in hours so the guardian resets when the FIRM says the day resets, not when the chart does. Leave at 0 if they match.

Group 6 · DISPLAY

Input	Default	What it does / when to change
Apply the built-in chart theme	true	The dark Relay theme. Display only.
Keep other indicators off	true	Keeps the chart clean. Display only.
Show the on-chart dashboard	true	The panel from section 2. Display only.

Draw past trades on the chart	true	Entry/exit markers with results. Display only.
Detailed log	false	Turn ON to have Relay print every signal, the verdict it reached and the full lot calculation into the Experts tab — this is how you audit the sizing yourself (see section 4). Leave OFF for normal running; it writes a lot.

Golden rule: the tested configuration lives inside the EA, not in a side file. On a fresh chart just attach it. Upgrading from an older Relay is the one case that needs care — press **Reset** in the Inputs tab, because MetaTrader silently carries your old values forward by input name.

5 · Broker, Environment & Money

What to run it on

Broker type	Raw-spread ECN. Relay was calibrated on IC Markets; Pepperstone-class raw accounts behave similarly. A broker that marks the spread up ~20 points silently costs about **4% of a year's profit** — measured, not guessed.
VPS	In the broker's datacenter region, round-trip ≤**100 ms**. At that latency the measured execution drag is zero; trading from a slow home connection cost up to 12% in storm periods in our delay stress-tests.
Account	USD, hedging mode, leverage 1:500 recommended. One chart, nothing else trading the account.
Server time	Nothing to configure. Relay takes its weekend timing from the **broker's own published trading session** rather than from your PC or VPS clock, so a server on GMT+0, GMT+2, GMT+3 or anything else all act at the same real market moment. A VPS with a wrong timezone cannot mistime it. Check the startup log line if you want to see the resolved time.

Money

Minimum balance	**$500** — a hard product constraint; below it the sizing ladder cannot work.
Recommended	**$1,000** — the figures in section 6 are measured here. It starts at 0.02 instead of 0.01, so a trending year earns considerably more (2025: $3,446 against $2,400). **Be aware of the honest trade-off:** the larger opening size also means deeper drawdowns, and in the stormy 2026 test year the $1,000 account actually finished BEHIND the $500 one ($2,092 against $2,883) with 17.2% balance drawdown against 8.8%. More capital buys a bigger ticket, not a smoother ride.
Risk profiles	Super Low (0.01 per $10,000) » Low » Medium » **High (default, 0.01 per $500)** » Custom step » Percent. In storm regimes the HIGH ladder automatically tightens to the more conservative step — a feature the other profiles do not carry. If you want a visibly calmer equity curve, **Medium** is the honest choice: about half the return, about half the drawdown.
Hard limits	Risk cap 5% per trade (skip, not shrink) · daily brake 3% · weekly brake 6% · prop guardian in prop mode.

6 · What To Expect — Both Directions

The good case (measured, recent years, $1,000 start, real ticks)

Retail	Roughly **+$2,100 to +$3,400 per year** on the recommended **$1,000** start with compounding — the two most recent full test years, not a projection. **Win rate 59-61%**. In twenty months of ledger, losing months were rare and **never consecutive**. At the $500 minimum the same years returned +$2,400 and +$2,883.
Prop	**+5.8% to +31%** annualised on $100k with equity drawdown held under **3%** — see section 3.

The bad case (equally measured, equally real)

Drawdown	Balance drawdowns of **17-18% happened inside profitable years** at a $1,000 start; equity dips ran to ~22%. If that number is unacceptable, choose a lower risk profile — the shape stays, the depth scales.
Losing runs	Three to four losing trades in a row is **normal operation**, and single losing months happen. The engine's best trades historically come right after losses — which is why Relay does not stop after a losing streak.
The real risk	A durable regime change in gold. Protections cap the damage rate, but no robot converts a hostile regime into profit — see *Our Honesty*. Run a demo first; judge Relay on months, not days.

Your first weeks — the part most vendors leave out

Everything above describes years. What you will actually see first is a handful of trades, and that is a different experience. These figures come from every possible starting day in the twenty-month test ledger at the $500 minimum — not from a chosen window.

Scratches	**About half of all trades close near zero.** Of any first eight trades, the typical count landing between roughly -$1 and +$4 is **four**. This is the design, not a fault: the quick engine takes most of the trades and produces a small share of the money, while a handful of trend trades carry the year. Expect a screen full of small numbers punctuated by a few large ones.
Dead band	A trade can show real open profit, have its stop moved to break-even, and still close at almost nothing. Measured frequency: a trade showing **$30 or more** at 0.01 lot and keeping nothing happens about **once a month**. It is the price of leaving the big winners alone — every tested alternative that rescued those scratches cost more on the runners than it saved here.
Start date	Your first impression is largely decided by **when you attach**, not by the robot. Across all possible start days: the first **8 trades are negative for 37%** of starts; the first **30 days for 10%**; the first **60 days for 0.4%**; the first **90 days for none**. Median first-60-days result was **+$440** on a $500 start.
Why it swings	A single trade can carry a month. In August 2026 one position returned **+$176.70 at 0.01 lot** and the month closed **+$882** — but a trader who attached two weeks later met only the quiet stretch that followed. The flat weeks are the admission price for the trades that pay.
The verdict	**Judge Relay at 60 days, not at 8 trades.** If a fortnight of small scratches and a couple of stop-outs would make you switch it off, run it on demo for two months first — that is a reasonable decision, and it is better made before your money is involved than after.

Disclaimer

Trading leveraged products involves substantial risk of loss and is not suitable for every investor. Past performance — including backtests on real tick data — does not guarantee future results. All figures in this guide are test measurements under stated conditions, not promises of return. You alone are responsible for your trading decisions and for compliance with your broker's and jurisdiction's rules. Never trade with money you cannot afford to lose; run a demo period before any live deployment. This document is not financial advice.

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